WORLD | 1,68,41,005 ACTIVE CASES | 31,20,321 DEATHS | 48.51 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

While on one end, India surpassed all countries in the world, barring the US, in the number of vaccine doses administered, on the other, on this day, we crossed two lakh daily cases just 10 days after clocking one lakh daily new cases.[26] The Dr Paul-led Empowered Group 1 had anticipated reaching peaks of two and a half to three lakh daily cases at the peak of the second wave, way back in September 2020 and the administration had prepared accordingly. They had also added in their September report that the pattern of the disease appeared to be an urban-concentrated one. Thus, cities were divided into five groups based on size and density; aggressive preparedness measures were undertaken in major ones such as Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru to be able to absorb 500 cases per million people per day. Any number significantly higher would quickly buckle our healthcare systems and create extreme shortages of medical supplies, ICU beds and oxygen. And that is exactly what followed. In the next seven days, by the third week of April, we crossed a grim figure of over three lakh new cases per day with no sign of the surge dying down[27], distributed unevenly with saturations in the northern and western states of the country. Most hospitals in the states which were hit hardest were filled to capacity with no beds to spare. From this point on, critically ill patients would have to be turned away. ICUs in hospitals were also maxed to capacity with coronavirus patients, all requiring oxygen support. This led to an even graver problem; these hospitals quickly began to run dangerously low on oxygen supplies, leaving it to the GoI to make additional oxygen allocations to states than planned.

While India had the capacity to meet the rising demand, it would require diverting most of the country's oxygen supply from industrial sites towards medical supplies.[28] A major problem however was that most of the steel plants were located in the eastern states of the country, from where it took anywhere between five to 10 days to transport the cryogenic tankers carrying LMO by road to the western and northern states, which saw high caseloads. This also meant that not only would it take long to transport the LMO to the states, but also that that many cryogenic tankers which were already in tight supply would be held up for as many days, as they would take the same amount of time to return for refilling. State governments began to make impractical requests. Maharashtra made a request to the